A 7-DAY PLAN FOR WOMEN 35+

The 6 P.M. Belly

Why you wake up flat and end the day tight, and the 7-day plan that finds your cause. Red flags included.

The Kira Method · 7-day plan · Morning drink · Fiber guide · Trigger test · Red flags

READ THIS FIRST

Flat at 8 a.m. Tight by 6 p.m.

We call it **the 6 p.m. belly**: a belly that is flat when you wake up and round by evening. If your waistband feels fine in the morning and tight by afternoon, you are not imagining it. Bloating comes and goes through the day, and it is one of the most common digestive complaints. Most of the time it has simple, fixable causes. This guide helps you find yours in seven days.

> **This is education, not medical advice.** Bloating is usually harmless, but not always. Read "When it is not just bloating" on the next page before you start. If your symptoms worry you, call your doctor.

> **Bloating is not the same as belly fat.** Belly fat stays. Bloating changes: it grows with meals, with stress, with certain foods and during your cycle, and it can shrink overnight. That is good news, because bloating can be worked on within days.

What you will do

1. Check the red flags (3 minutes).
2. Learn the six usual suspects, and test the likely ones.
3. Follow a 7-day plan with one small change a day.
4. Use the fiber guide and trigger test if something still bothers you.
5. Take your log to your doctor if it does not improve.

STEP 1

When it is not just bloating

Most bloating is harmless. But new, constant bloating can sometimes be a sign of something that needs a doctor. Please read this list before you try anything at home.

Call your doctor if your bloating:

- is new for you, happens most days, and lasts more than two to three weeks;
- comes with pelvic or belly pain, feeling full very quickly when you eat, or needing to pee much more often;
- comes with unexplained weight loss, blood in your stool, black stools, repeated vomiting, or trouble swallowing;
- comes with constant swelling in your ankles or legs, swelling in only one leg, or shortness of breath.

Bloating, pelvic or belly pain, trouble eating or feeling full quickly, and needing to urinate urgently are a combination that should be checked, especially if it is new and does not go away. Do not wait for a "reset" to fix it, and do not feel embarrassed. A doctor visit is the right step.

Sources agree that symptoms that are new, persistent and frequent, and not explained by your diet, deserve a medical evaluation. Write down when it started, how often it happens, and whether it is getting better or worse.

If none of those fit, go on. Most women find that two or three small habits change a lot.

STEP 2

The six usual suspects

Suspect	What it looks like	Easy test (3 days)
1. Swallowed air	Burping, gassy, worse after eating fast, drinking with a straw, chewing gum or sipping fizzy drinks.	Eat each meal over 20 minutes. No gum, hard candy, straws or fizzy drinks.
2. A slow gut	Fewer than one comfortable bowel movement a day, straining, heavy belly that gets better after you go.	More water, daily walk, gentle fiber increase (see Step 4).
3. Fiber too low or raised too fast	Low fiber can slow things down. A sudden jump in fiber or a new fiber powder can cause gas and bloating.	Count your fiber for 3 days. Change by about 5 g a week, not overnight.
4. A trigger food	Symptoms 30 minutes to several hours after dairy, beans, onions, garlic, "sugar-free" gum or candy, or certain fruits.	Food and symptom log (Step 5). Change one food at a time.
5. Fluid and hormones	Puffiness before your period, after a salty meal, or with ankle marks from socks.	Notice the pattern in your log, drink water, go easy on very salty foods, move your legs.
6. Stress, sleep and sitting	Belly gets tight on rushed, stressful or desk-bound days.	A 10-minute walk after meals, slow breathing, a calm first bite.

Persistent ankle swelling is different. If your socks leave deep marks every day, or you have swelling that does not go down overnight, tell your doctor. It can come from many causes, and some need treatment.

The U.S. National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases says that swallowing less air can ease gas and bloating, and lists gum and hard candy among the habits to skip. Carbonated drinks are a known contributor.

STEP 3

The 7-day plan

One small change per day. Keep the earlier ones going. Tick each day when done, and rate your bloating 0–5 at 8 a.m. and 6 p.m.

Day	Do this	Done
Day 1	**Baseline.** Eat as usual. Write down food, drink, bowel movements, and your bloating rating morning and evening.	☐
Day 2	**Slow down.** Put your fork down between bites. Take at least 20 minutes for each meal. Chew well.	☐
Day 3	**Cut the air.** No gum, hard candy, straws or fizzy drinks (including sparkling water) for today.	☐
Day 4	**Water and the morning drink.** Start with the warm lemon and chia drink below. Sip water through the day.	☐
Day 5	**Move after meals.** A short, easy walk after at least two meals. Add 5 minutes of the gentle moves in Step 6.	☐
Day 6	**Trigger check.** Look at your log. Pick one suspect food and skip only that one today.	☐
Day 7	**Review.** Compare day 1 and day 7. What helped most? Keep that. If nothing changed, take your log to your doctor.	☐

The morning drink

Warm lemon and chia. Warm water in a glass or pot, juice of one fresh lemon, one teaspoon of chia seeds, and a pinch of turmeric if you like it. Stir and let it sit about 10 minutes until the chia turns soft and gel-like. Sip it slowly before breakfast.

Why: chia adds fiber and holds water, and warm fluid is an easy way to get a full glass in before coffee. It is a habit, not a cure.

Safety: always soak chia first, never eat it dry, and drink fluids with it. If you have trouble swallowing, or you take medicines for blood pressure or blood sugar, ask your doctor first.

Do not use this drink to replace meals. Skip it if it upsets your stomach.

STEP 4

Fiber guide

Adult women are generally advised to get about 25 grams of fiber a day (sources give 21 to 26 grams). Many American women eat far less. Fiber helps stool move, but too much too fast causes gas, bloating and sometimes diarrhea.

> **The rule:** go up by about 5 grams a week, and drink water as you do.

Food	Portion	Fiber (approx.)
Raspberries	1 cup	~8 g
Lentils, cooked	1/2 cup	~8 g
Black beans, cooked	1/2 cup	~7–8 g
Broccoli, cooked	1 cup	~5 g
Pear, with skin	1 medium	~5–6 g
Chia seeds	1 tablespoon	~4–5 g
Apple, with skin	1 medium	~4–5 g
Oats, dry	1/2 cup	~4 g
Almonds	1/4 cup	~4 g
Whole-wheat bread	1 slice	~2 g

Typical values. Labels vary.

Good to know

- **Soluble fiber** (oats, chia, psyllium, flaxseed, barley) is gentler for many people with bloating or irritable bowel syndrome. Add it slowly. Ask your doctor before you start a fiber supplement.
- If you have irritable bowel syndrome, diverticulitis, or a bowel condition, ask your doctor what fiber is right for you.

STEP 5

Trigger test: find your food

If you suspect a food, test it with one change at a time. Cutting out many foods at once leaves you unsure of what helped, and can leave you short on nutrients.

1. **Keep a log for 3 days:** what you ate, when, and how you felt over the next 1–4 hours.
2. **Pick one suspect:** for example milk, "sugar-free" candy or gum, beans, onion or garlic, or a fizzy drink.
3. **Skip it for 2 weeks** (a common method), keep everything else the same.
4. **Add it back** in a normal portion on one day, and watch for the next 24 hours.
5. If it brings symptoms back, you found a trigger. Try a smaller amount, or a different form.

Common culprits: lactose (milk, soft cheese, ice cream), sugar alcohols (sorbitol, xylitol, mannitol in "sugar-free" products), beans and lentils, onions and garlic, apples and pears for some people, and fizzy drinks.

Be careful with strict diets. A "low-FODMAP" diet is meant to be short-term and is usually done with a registered dietitian. Do not cut major food groups for long periods on your own.

Food and symptom log

Time	What I ate or drank	Symptoms (0–5) and when

STEP 6

Gentle moves for a tight belly

Movement helps gas move through. These take five minutes. Do them in the evening or after a meal (wait about 20 minutes after eating for the floor moves).

Move	How	Time
Easy walk	Walk at a comfortable pace after meals. A short walk can lower the blood sugar rise after a meal. The ideal length has not been proven, so start with 5–10 minutes.	5–10 min
Knees to chest	Lie on your back, hug both knees toward your chest, breathe slowly.	5 breaths
Cat–cow	On hands and knees, arch and round your back slowly with your breath.	8 rounds
Seated twist	Sit tall, turn gently to one side holding the chair back, switch.	3 each side
Belly breathing	Hand on belly, inhale through your nose and let it rise, exhale slowly through your mouth.	2 minutes

Stop if you feel sharp pain. Do not do floor moves if you have a hernia, recent surgery or any condition that your doctor has told you to avoid.

Your 7-day tracker

Day	Bloat 8 a.m. (0–5)	Bloat 6 p.m. (0–5)	Bowel movement?	Walk?	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					

IF IT DOES NOT IMPROVE

Take this to your doctor

Bring your 7-day log, and use these questions.

☐ What could be causing my bloating, and what have we ruled out?

☐ Could it be constipation, irritable bowel syndrome, lactose intolerance, celiac disease, or something else?

☐ Do I need any tests, and which ones?

☐ Is a fiber supplement or a change in my medicines worth trying?

☐ Should I see a registered dietitian or a gastroenterologist?

☐ Which symptoms should make me call you sooner?

Week-1 shopping list. Lemons, chia seeds, oats, berries (raspberries if you like them), apples or pears, lentils or beans, broccoli, plain yogurt or kefir if you tolerate dairy, eggs, fish, chicken, water you enjoy, herbal tea (peppermint or ginger).

Notes

SOURCES

Where this comes from

Written October 2026. Check with your own care team.

- National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases (NIDDK), "Gas in the Digestive Tract" (niddk.nih.gov): swallowing less air, skipping gum and hard candy, carbonated drinks, when to see a doctor.
- Cancer centers and public health agencies on ovarian cancer symptoms (bloating, pelvic or belly pain, trouble eating or feeling full quickly, urinary urgency): symptoms that are new, frequent and persistent for more than two to three weeks should be evaluated by a doctor.
- U.S. Dietary Guidelines and NIH: fiber about 25 g a day for adult women (reported range 21–26 g); increase gradually with enough fluid.
- Irritable bowel syndrome diet guidance: soluble fiber such as psyllium, oats and chia; low-FODMAP diet used short-term with a registered dietitian.
- Buffey et al., 2022, meta-analysis of short walks after meals and blood sugar (the best length has not been established).

> This guide is educational. It is not medical advice, diagnosis or treatment, and it does not create a doctor–patient relationship. Talk to your doctor before you change your diet, start supplements, or if your symptoms worry you. Individual results vary and no specific outcome is promised.

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